

Checklist:

Software Managers' Operational Excellence Checklist

Based on the article "[Software Managers' Guide to Operational Excellence](#)" by Kate Matsudaira. Keys to success:

- Invest in quality assurance.
- Automate repetitive/manual tasks.
- Standardize and improve engineering processes.
- Measure and track performance data.
- Foster a culture of continuous improvement.

Launch Readiness

- ☐ Monitoring and dashboards are working and accessible.
- ☐ Runbooks/playbooks exist and are understandable by unfamiliar team members.
- ☐ Service-Level Objectives (SLOs) are defined and tracked.
- ☐ Disaster recovery plans and backups are in place and tested.
- ☐ Dependency failure behavior is understood (e.g., graceful degradation).
- ☐ Load and performance testing have been conducted.
- ☐ Compliance requirements (security, privacy, regulations) are met.

Incident Management

- ☐ An incident review process (retrospectives, RCAs) has been established.
- ☐ Incident follow-up items are tracked and completed.
- ☐ Alert volume is measured; high volumes are addressed.
- ☐ Incident response quality is reviewed (e.g., SME coverage, focus on resolution).
- ☐ Weekly reviews of open incident action items occur.

On-Call Management

- ☐ Defined on-call schedule and rotation length.
- ☐ Backup plans are in place when someone doesn't respond to a pager.
- ☐ On-call engineers have the right skills, tools, and permissions.
- ☐ On-call pain (paging frequency, hours) is evaluated and minimized.
- ☐ Clear expectations about feature work during on-call duty.
- ☐ Rotation selection is fair and well-structured.

Operational Data & System Health

- ☐ Dashboards provide visibility into the health of the system and business.
- ☐ Dashboards are reviewed regularly.
- ☐ Awareness of current feature flags, marketing campaigns, and sales events.

- ☐ Systems scale elastically, and thresholds are known.

Customer Issue Tracking

- ☐ Frequency and type of customer-reported issues are tracked.
- ☐ Trends in customer issues are analyzed (growing/shrinking).
- ☐ Quality management is considered in the context of new features.
- ☐ Frequency of timeouts, errors, or crashes is tracked (especially mobile).

Failover & Recovery

- ☐ Disaster recovery plans are documented and tested.
- ☐ Systems degrade gracefully when needed.
- ☐ Time to full recovery is measured and optimized.

CI/CD, Testing, and Automation

- ☐ High confidence in deployment quality.
- ☐ Canary releases or feature flags are used for gradual rollouts.
- ☐ Synthetic and real-user monitoring (RUM) are in place for key flows.
- ☐ Systems have adequate observability and instrumentation.

☐ Rollback/failover to a known good instance is always possible.